the soon-to-be-held board meeting would be unlike any other ever held. Reportedly, as soon as Ratan and Nohria left his room, a disturbed Mistry texted his wife Rohiqa, stating, ‘I am being sacked.’

Mistry had perhaps hoped that he could inveigle the majority of the directors into supporting him. His confidence was, however, misplaced. Ratan and his team were prepared.

By 3 p.m., everyone except Ratan arrived in the boardroom. The Tata Trusts nominee directors, Singh, Amit Chandra and Nohria, had already reached and so had Ronen Sen, Venu Srinivasan, Ajay Piramal, Ishaat Hussain and Farida Khambata. Farokh Subedar, company secretary, was also in attendance. The last three, however, had absolutely no idea as to what was going to unfold that afternoon.

Mistry was there too. He looked ‘dishevelled, distraught, ashen and angry all at once’, recalls Singh. Ratan was the last to arrive. He walked in without uttering a word and sat down. This was his first meeting of the board of Tata Sons as chairman emeritus. The meeting was held in camera; no one else was allowed into the room, not even the liveried waiters who were usually present bearing silver trays with tea or coffee and only cane sugar to sweeten the beverage (the Tatas, being staunch traditionalists, serve no artificial sweeteners), accompanied by pastries, almond cookies, fruit cake and chocolate pastry from the Taj.

Before the meeting formally began, Amit Chandra announced that the Tata Trusts had, earlier in the day, taken a decision to move a motion to request Cyrus Mistry, executive chairman of Tata Sons, to step down as Tata Trusts had ‘lost confidence in him for a variety of reasons’. He added that Ratan had just met Mistry and had requested him to step down but the latter had declined.

With this introduction, he renewed the request to Mistry to reconsider his decision before the formal meeting started. Mistry ignored the request and attempted to draw Ratan into the proceedings by requesting him to speak. But the effort failed. The chairman emeritus politely declined, stating that he would prefer to be an observer.

Chandra thereafter sought Mistry’s opinion on the resolution. A visibly agitated Mistry kept repeating, ‘This is illegal, this is illegal, you can’t do this.’ He punctuated this with the declaration of his intent, ‘I need to get legal opinion’; ‘I request fifteen days’ time to give my reply’; ‘Under the